

Philadelphia Science Museum Closes as Supporters Seek a Way to Reopen

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The Academy of Natural Sciences museum in Philadelphia closed on September 30. Founded in 1812, it opened to the public in 1828. In 1868, it became the first place in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton.

For many local families, visiting was a special tradition. Alexandria McCormick visited with her husband and six children. She said childhood visits helped her love nature. She felt sad that her children might miss similar experiences.

The Academy has more than 19 million **specimens**. A **specimen** is a sample of a plant, animal or fossil kept for study. The collection includes Thomas Jefferson's fossils and plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark. Drexel University said students and researchers would keep access to the collection. Public access remains unclear.

Drexel took over financial responsibility for the Academy in 2011. It said costs rose and fewer people visited after the pandemic. When the closing was announced on September 1, thousands of families came for a final visit. In its last few weeks, museum **revenue** was more than 20 times higher than last September.

Some supporters criticized Drexel for the short notice and for not sharing the cost of keeping the museum open. Drexel said it remained committed to protecting the Academy's history and collections.

Before the closing, the William Penn Foundation offered **funding** for one year. This would give people time to explore lasting solutions. Drexel said it was exploring the offer but needed a long-term plan before considering reopening. Philadelphia's city council plans public **hearings** to learn how the closure happened and explore solutions.

Word Treasure

specimen -- A sample of a plant, animal or fossil kept for study.

revenue -- Money received by an organization.

funding -- Money provided to support an activity or organization.

hearings -- Meetings where people share information and answer questions.

Background you need

The Academy was founded in 1812 and opened to the public in 1828.

Its collection includes Thomas Jefferson's fossils and plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark.

Break it down

Reports the museum's closure and its history.

Describes a family's connection to the museum.

Explains the collection and questions about access.

Presents Drexel's explanation and supporters' concerns.

Describes the funding offer and planned public hearings.

Why it matters

The closure affects a place where families learned about nature. Students and researchers will retain collection access, but public access and reopening remain uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. Where is the Academy of Natural Sciences museum?
 - ☐ (A) Boston
 - ☐ (B) Washington
 - ☐ (C) Philadelphia
 - ☐ (D) New York
2. What did the Academy display in 1868?
 - ☐ (A) A space capsule
 - ☐ (B) A dinosaur skeleton
 - ☐ (C) A plant collection
 - ☐ (D) A giant telescope
3. How did childhood visits affect Alexandria McCormick?
 - ☐ (A) They helped her learn music.
 - ☐ (B) They helped her study cooking.
 - ☐ (C) They helped her love nature.
 - ☐ (D) They helped her enjoy sports.
4. What changes did Drexel report after the pandemic?
 - ☐ (A) Higher costs and more visitors
 - ☐ (B) Higher costs and fewer visitors
 - ☐ (C) Lower costs and more visitors
 - ☐ (D) Lower costs and fewer visitors
5. How long would the foundation's offered funding last?
 - ☐ (A) One year
 - ☐ (B) One month
 - ☐ (C) Six months
 - ☐ (D) Ten years
6. Who did Drexel say would keep access to the collection?
 - ☐ (A) Tourists and tour guides
 - ☐ (B) Athletes and coaches
 - ☐ (C) Students and researchers
 - ☐ (D) Artists and musicians

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Alexandria McCormick:** She said childhood visits helped her love nature and felt sad that her children might miss similar experiences.
2. **Drexel University:** It reported rising costs and fewer visitors after the pandemic and said reopening would require a long-term plan.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):